

There's more to Flash

With Android supporting Flash 10.1 content, you will soon see set-top boxes and maybe even Google TV running Flash content

Open Screen Project

A project that aims to provide a consistent runtime environment for open web browsing and standalone applications built on Flash Platform on various devices

"The recent development of Papervision 3D (incorporates 3D into Flash) and the ability to simulate augmented reality in Flash gives it a lot of scope for both experience based advertising, gaming and online availability," says Abhilash.

Certifications and training

Both career oriented and tool specific courses are available from various training institutes such as NIIT, Arena, Tekno Point Multimedia, Animaster (Bangalore), etc. Training institutes offer both design as well as development/programming tailored courses. The Career courses are usually the best choice and are structured towards an objective. For instance the two new courses at Tekno Point offer training in two streams – either to help you become a Digital Content Designer or RIA Developer. So these kind of courses are not tool specific i.e. learning either Flash or Flex or Illustrator. Instead they will help you get familiar with whatever tools you need to learn to achieve your desired skill be it Acrobat, ActionScript or Flex. There are also short courses for working professionals that last no more than 10 days. These short courses help you transition from other programming backgrounds to Flex.

As for certification, there are two main accreditations offered by Adobe in this field. Adobe Certified Associate is an entry level qualification. It's for people who use Adobe products, usually as students as part of a college curriculum, and want an official certification to qualify their abilities. Adobe Certified Expert is for working professionals who are into Adobe products already and want to enhance their career. While ACA is general, ACE on the other hand is specific to a particular tool from Adobe. You can become an ACE Master in Flash, Photoshop and Illustrator. "It gives you a distinct identity if you've cleared these certifications. There are several Adobe training partners such as Tekno Point that offer training for these exams, while to actually take the exams you have to go to any of the testing centers in India," adds Mody.

Let the games begin

Game development in Flash is one of the most exciting and high paying verticals in this sector. Anyone who has learnt Flash

from the development standpoint would most certainly be interested in game development. Most of the Flash developers in India are into e-learning – which is a more simplistic from a development standpoint. Their coding logic is very linear. In gaming you have to use physics and more complex algorithms to make a fun game.

There's a lot of opportunity across the gaming industry for qualified Flash developers, supported by an acute shortage resulting in a lot of competition to get the best people. "The opportunities for game development are not just casual gaming which are PC based or browser / downloadable games, there are larger scale games such as virtual worlds and massively multiplayer online games also being done in Flash. The backends often end up being PHP with the programming done in Java. But the entire front end is handled in Flash," says Robin Alter, CTO and Founder, Kreed Games India Pvt. Ltd.

Flash and Flex make it easy to make games and applications but at the interna-



"I suggest building a two player game on any of the multiplayer engines that exist, to see how messages, and interactivity are done between two cross clients, how media can be dynamically served into a flash file to create an ever changing virtual world. Learning these kinds of things is where everyone is going"

Robin Alter, CTO and Founder, Kreed Games India Pvt. Ltd.

tional level, companies such as Kreed look at the quality of code, the re-usability of the code, and whether a person optimises the game. Emphasis is laid on the efficiency of the code as well as the performance. Candidates are given simple tasks to ascertain whether they think in an object oriented manner and see if "their code is elegant." People who have come from Java into Flash often come with a good set of skills. The syntax is similar and the migration is easier. People with good Flash programming skills can pick up Flex more easily than vice versa. "Apart from having a good academic record a person needs to have a good eye for details and logical reasoning. This helps in working on the game concept and to visualize the game before getting down to actual development", says Deepak Abbot, VP-Product, Zapak Digital Entertainment.

Certification Help

- **Find a training partner at** http://partners.adobe.com/public/partnerfinder/tp/show_find.do (Look for Product for eg "Adobe Flex" and country as "India")
- **Find info on training and certification at -** <http://www.adobe.com/training/> and <http://www.adobe.com/support/certification/>
- **To look at the various steps involved in ACE Certifications go to** http://www.adobe.com/support/certification/ace_certify.html
- **To locate a testing center near you head over to** <http://www.pearsonvue.com/Adobe/locate/>

As a game developer you would generally start as a junior developer and then progress to developer, then senior developer, next comes project lead and then a tech lead. A junior developer with say a year and a half of experience on Flash can get anywhere from ₹3.5 to 4.5 lakhs per annum. It goes up considerably after each level. "I've interviewed people that are in the 20 lakhs range. People with around ten years of expe-

rience are in the 30 lakhs range. These high pay scales are for tech leads doing multiple projects and doing very complex stuff like large scale social games" says Robin.

One would think game designing would require a high degree of creativity. "You know what, I don't stress so much on creativity from a game development or programming standpoint because a game developer is not required to be a game designer. They're separate roles. But creativity does help". To be a good game developer in Flash also requires you to do R&D. The gaming environment is ever changing – there's always new technology, there are always new challenges therefore you need to be constantly interacting with the international community, constantly finding out how to do new things. Gaming is about new innovations.